

As single-parent households are on the rise, so, too, are blended families. The two-parents-and-three-kids formula of the 1950s is no longer the norm. Today's families are more complex, many formed by second and third marriages. Statistics Canada has always provided data for "intact families"—families with no incidence of divorce or remarriage—but for the first time in 2011, the census also measured the number of stepfamilies in the country. Out of 3.7 million two-parent families with children, 12.6 percent are stepfamilies. One out of every 10 children in Canada is now a member of a blended family.

Stepfamilies bring their own challenges, but I believe it's better to get remarried than to live out the rest of your days alone. Why? Because remarriage is the single best decision you can make for your financial dynasty—provided you've learned from the first and that this one will last.

Getting remarried after a period of single parenthood can ease your financial responsibilities and put more money in the bank. Statistically, there is *no significant difference* between the family income of parents in stepfamilies and those in intact families. If you stay single, however, the odds are stacked against you: 49 percent of lone-parent families have a household income of less than \$50,000. Compare that to just 16 percent of stepfamilies. When you look at the numbers, stepfamilies actually perform quite well, with 41 percent netting an annual income of \$100,000 or more. But only 9 percent of lone-parent families ever make it to 100 k. As you can see from the following table, the cost of remaining single is just too high.

HOUSEHOLD INCOME OF INTACT, STEP- AND LONE-PARENT FAMILIES